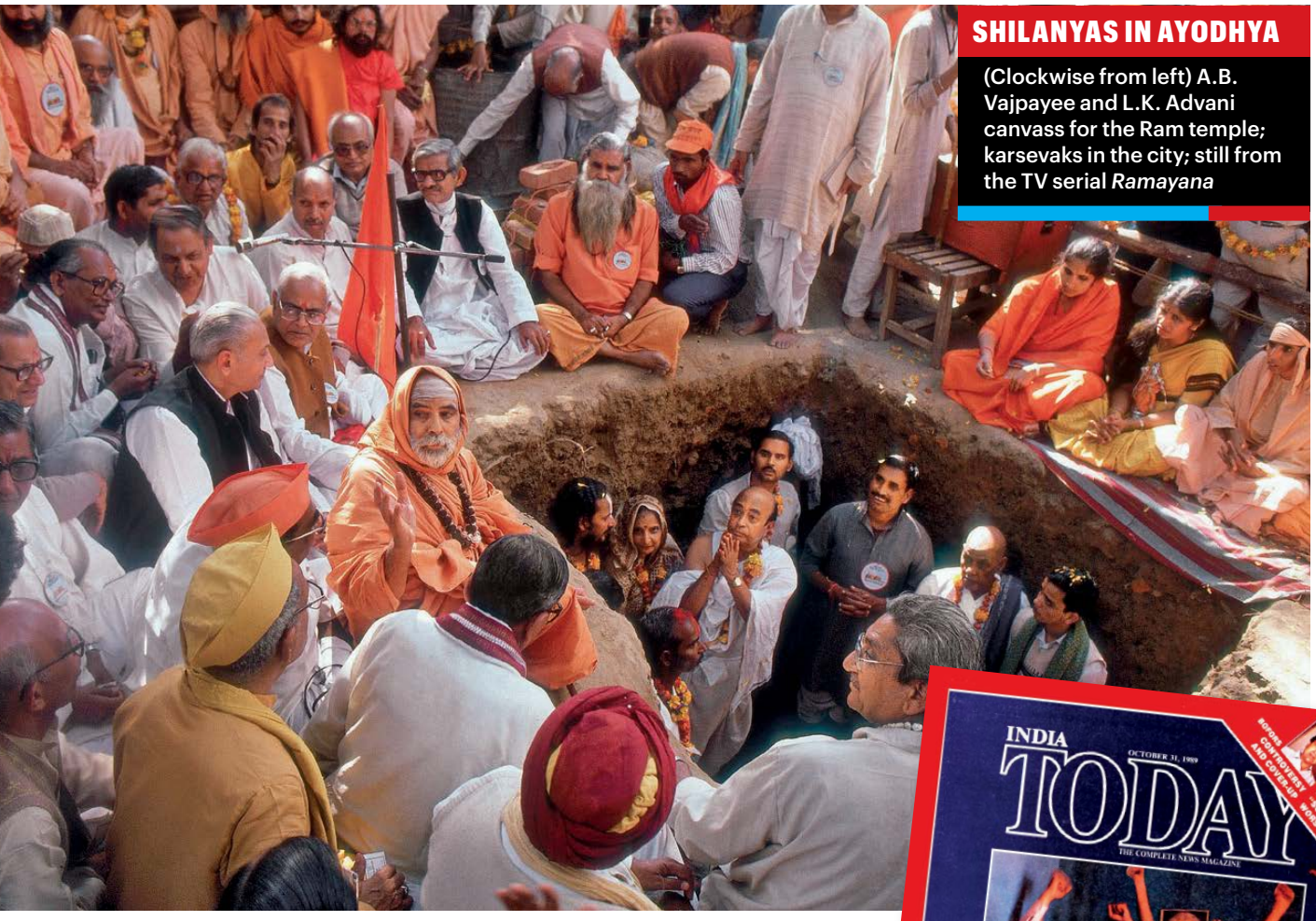
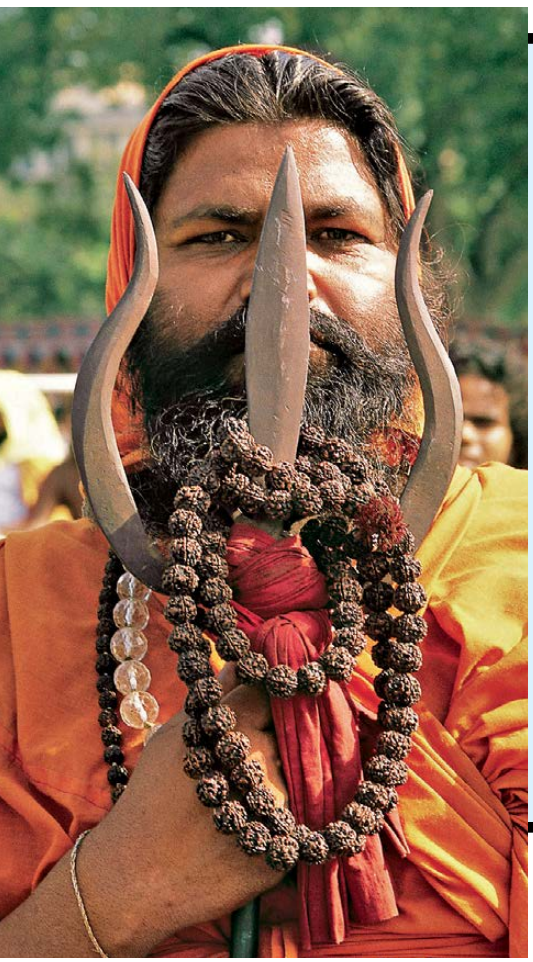
SHILANYAS IN AYODHYA

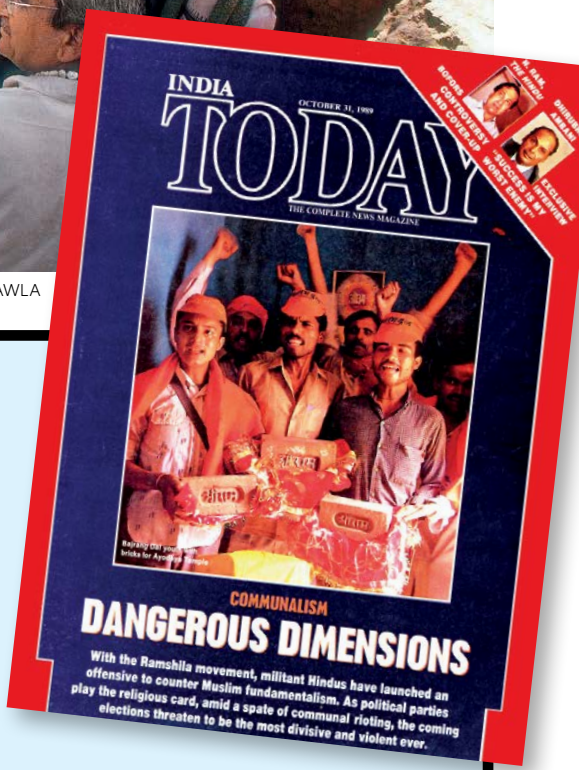
(Clockwise from left) A.B. Vajpayee and L.K. Advani canvass for the Ram temple; karsevaks in the city; still from the TV serial *Ramayana*



JOGINDER CHAWLA



PRAMOD PUSHKARNA



Dangerous Dimensions
Oct. 31, 1989

"According to a top secret Intelligence Bureau study: "Mutual distrust between communities remains at a high level. The number of riots classified 'serious' is higher than in 1986."... The beatific smile of Ram in VHP posters has been replaced by a warlike image—trident and bow at the ready. The slogans, too, have changed. Earlier they were: *Saugandh Ram ki khaate hain hum mandir vaheen banayenge* (We swear by Ram we will build the temple at the same site) and *Bachcha-bachcha Ram ka Janmabhoomi ke kaam ka* (Every child belongs to Ram and for Ram Janmabhoomi). Now the air is rent with: *Jis Hindu ka khoon na khaule, khoon nahin vo paani hai; Janmabhoomi ke kaam na aye, vo bekaar jawani hai* (That Hindu whose blood does not boil has water in his veins, youth that does not serve Ram Janmabhoomi is youth lived in vain)."